

Isocolon and comparative construal: A corpus test of rhetorical balance

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Abstract

Rhetorical theory often treats ISOCOLON as more than ornamental balance. A balanced pair of clauses can make a comparison feel more explicit, pointed, or forceful. A reader-side causal claim would need experimental evidence, but a production-side claim can be tested in corpus data. This paper proposes a narrow test: among adjacent clause pairs with comparable syntactic opportunity for parallelism, are comparison relations more isocolonic than contrast, cause, condition, sequence, or elaboration relations? The design treats isocolon as a graded textual property rather than a binary label, models clause pairs within texts and genres, and separates comparative relation from the parallel syntax that comparison often invites. If the association survives those controls, the result would support a textual-function claim: isocolon is preferentially selected where writers construe two units as comparable.

I INTRODUCTION

At Rhetoricon, held at the University of Waterloo on 2026-05-29, Gini Fahnestock proposed that ISOCOLON makes comparison more salient, pointed, explicit, or forceful. The question for this project is how far a corpus study can test that claim without turning into a reader experiment.

Fahnestock's broader work treats rhetorical figures as forms that do argumentative work rather than as detachable ornament (Fahnestock, 1999, 2011). That makes the corpus question worth asking, but it also makes overclaiming easy.

The answer has to be level-specific. At the reader-response level, the claim is causal: isocolon changes how a comparison is perceived. A corpus study can't establish that. At the corpus level, the claim is different: writers may preferentially use balanced clauses when construing two units as comparable. That claim is testable.

2 TARGET CLAIM

The first target is deliberately narrow. In naturally occurring rhetorical prose, isocolon should be more frequent in comparison relations than in matched non-comparison relations, once genre, text, clause length, syntactic frame, connective type, and general parallelism are controlled.

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That would not show that readers experience the comparison as more forceful. The result would show that formal balance is part of the textual profile of comparative construal. The rhetorical-function claim would then rest on production-side textual evidence rather than psychometric response data.

3 DESIGN

The unit of analysis is the adjacent clause pair or colon pair. Each pair receives a discourse-relation label, with comparison contrasted against contrast, cause, condition, temporal sequence, and elaboration. Each pair also receives a graded isocolon score, combining token-length balance, syllable or stress balance where feasible, syntactic parallelism, and lexical parallelism.

The main model should estimate whether comparison predicts higher isocolon scores after partial pooling by text, author or speaker where known, genre, and period. The analysis should treat the isocolon measure and the discourse-relation labels as noisy. A fake-data simulation should come first, to check whether a realistically sized hand-coded corpus could recover an effect if one existed.

4 SECOND TEST

A second non-experimental test would strengthen the inference. Revision data, where available, can ask whether writers add or preserve isocolon when sharpening comparison. If draft-to-final changes increase balance specifically in comparative pairs, then isocolon is not merely a by-product of comparison syntax. It's a selected feature of rhetorical shaping.

The two tests would converge on different parts of the claim. The matched corpus study asks whether isocolon is associated with comparison relations. The revision study asks whether writers select isocolon while making a comparison rhetorically sharper.

5 CONCLUSION

The project should not claim that isocolon causes readers to perceive comparison as more forceful. It can make a stronger and cleaner textual claim: isocolon is a conventional formal resource for marking comparative construal. If that claim holds under matched corpus and revision tests, the production-side evidence would be substantial.

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